

# POLS 350/450

## Religion and Politics in Comparative Perspective

Summer Session 2024

Monday July 1-Thurs Aug 8 T/R 4-6:50pm

Nandini Deo [ndd208@lehigh.edu](mailto:ndd208@lehigh.edu)

2034155351 Office-MG 306

This research seminar attempts to identify the conditions under which religious parties arise and become influential, how religion influences popular understandings of secular politics and the extent to which religion is a necessary feature of modern public discourse. These topics are explored through country specific cases from around the world.

### Learning objectives

- Understand how religion and politics mutually shape each other
- Deconstruct the secular/religious binary
- Apply theoretical concepts to real world cases
- Collaborate in class through discussion and writing
- Recognize and integrate personal perspectives into scholarship

### Assignments and grading

- Positionality paper 10%
- Start of class questions 10%
- End of class reflections 20%
- Research workshop 20%
- Research project (essay or [unessay](#)) 30%
- Course Reflection 10%

## Required Readings available at LU bookstore

- *Weirdest People in the World* by Joe Henrich
- *The Complete Maus* by Art Spiegelman
- *Palestine* by Joe Sacco

## University and Class Policies on Inclusion

The University asks us to include this exact language here: “Accommodations for Students with Disabilities Lehigh University is committed to maintaining an equitable and inclusive community and welcomes students with disabilities into all of the University’s educational programs. In order to receive consideration for reasonable accommodations, a student with a disability must contact Disability Support Services (DSS), provide documentation, and participate in an interactive review process. If the documentation supports a request for reasonable accommodations, DSS will provide students with a Letter of Accommodations. Students who are approved for accommodations at Lehigh should share this letter and discuss their accommodations and learning needs with instructors as early in the semester as possible. For more information or to request services, please contact Disability Support Services in person in Williams Hall, Suite 301, via phone at 610-758-4152, via email at [indss@lehigh.edu](mailto:indss@lehigh.edu), or online at <https://studentaffairs.lehigh.edu/disabilities>.”

My own statement on disabilities includes that, I recognize that not all students can provide the documentation needed by the DSS office. I encourage you to reach out to them and see how they can support you. However, if you need accommodations immediately, please let me know directly and I will make every effort to support your learning. I am working on adopting Universal Design into my courses, but if there is something specific that would make the class more accessible, I would love to hear about it.

“The Principles of Our Equitable Community: Lehigh University endorses The Principles of Our Equitable Community [[http://www.lehigh.edu/~inprv/initiatives/PrinciplesEquity\\_Sheet\\_v2\\_032212.pdf](http://www.lehigh.edu/~inprv/initiatives/PrinciplesEquity_Sheet_v2_032212.pdf)]. We expect each member of this class to acknowledge and practice these Principles. Respect for each other and for differing viewpoints is a vital component of the learning environment inside and outside the classroom.”

My experience at Lehigh is that we can create “brave spaces” in our classes- through respectful engagement we can have difficult conversations which allow each of us to learn from each other. I approach you as a valued contributor and ask that you do the

same for everyone else in our course. If I, or anyone in the class, does or says something that makes you uncomfortable, please do let me know. We are all learning together, and our mistakes are often our most memorable teachers.

## Schedule of Classes

Jul 2, 2024 Introductions

Read McCutcheon

Write positionality paper

Brainstorm course questions

Jul 9, 2024 Cultural Evolution of Religion

*Weirdest People in the World* by Joe Henrich Parts 1 and 2

Jul 11, 2024 Cultural Evolution of Religion

*Weirdest People in the World* by Joe Henrich Part 3

Jul 16, 2024 Shoah 1

Maus Vol 1 and 2

<https://www.theatlantic.com/books/archive/2022/11/maus-art-spiegelman-book-ban-anti-semitism/672203/>

Jul 18, 2024

Shoah 2

Holy Silence Documentary on Kanopy

<https://www.pbs.org/wnet/religionandethics/2001/08/03/august-3-2001-holocaust-survivors-the-search-for-faith/13853/>

Jul 23, 2024 Gaza

Palestine by Joe Sacco

<https://www.vox.com/2023/10/7/23907683/israel-hamas-war-news-updates-october-2023>

<https://www.theosthinktank.co.uk/comment/2023/11/14/a-religious-war-misconceptions-about-the-role-of-religion-in-the-israelipalestinian-conflict>  
<https://foreignpolicy.com/2024/03/07/israel-palestine-hamas-gaza-religious-war/>

Jul 25, 2024 Research and Writing Workshop

Email your 2 page outline of your research project by **July 25 at 9am**.

Read each other's outlines and be ready to comment productively on them.

Jul 29, 2024 Christian Nationalism in the USA

<https://www.imdb.com/title/tt29259251/>

<https://wondery.com/shows/thealfrankenpodcast/episode/11995-tim-alberta-on-evangelicals-in-an-age-of-extremism/>

Aug 1, 2024 Christian Nationalism and Reproductive Rights

<https://msmagazine.com/2024/02/28/women-choice-freedom-republicans-religion-ivf-fertility/>

<https://www.politico.com/news/magazine/2024/03/21/life-conception-christian-theology-0147804>

<https://www.pewresearch.org/religion/2024/03/15/religions-role-in-public-life/>

Aug 6, 2024 Research presentations

Aug 8, 2024 Research presentations

Aug 10 Course Reflection Due